

November 26, 1940, in his political testament. "If he does lose anything of the earth, he will gain much more by becoming the heir to a life immortal." Governor John Herbert decided to send him home on December 5, 1940, having resolved to arrest him again as soon as he had recovered his health. "If he resorts to a hunger strike again," Herbert blithely wrote to viceroy Linlithgow on December 11, 1940, "the present 'cat and mouse' policy will be continued, and its employment will serve both to render him innocuous and to make him realise that nothing is to be

terrain of the tribal territories in the North West Frontier crossing the territorial limits of Britain's Indian empire on January 26 and reaching Kabul on January 31, 1941. His family had announced in Calcutta on January 26 that he could not be found, leaving British intelligence officers shame-faced and bewildered.

Why had the man who had espoused Left-wing socialist views as President of the Indian National Congress in 1938 and 1939 chosen to come to Nazi Germany in 1941? Bose had made up his mind that at the climactic moment of India's anti-im-

perialist struggle the loyalty of Indian men in arms to the British King-Emperor had to be replaced by a new allegiance to the cause of Indian independence. Germany's invasion of the Soviet Union in June 1941 put paid to Bose's plans for an invasion from the north-west. But Japan's sweeping victories in Southeast Asia in early 1942 opened India's north-eastern frontier to the army of liberation of his dreams. Not only were there many more Indian soldiers in Japanese hands, but the presence of nearly three million Indian expatriates in Asia gave Bose's movement a much larger civilian social base of support. Mahatma Gandhi best captured the significance of the Indian National Army (INA) saga that unfolded between 1943 and 1945. The trial at the Red Fort of some leading officers took the story of INA and its *Netaji* to every Indian home. "The whole country has been roused," Gandhi observed, "and even the regular forces have been stirred into a new political consciousness and have begun to think in terms of Independence." As Bose's 'Father of Our Nation' said about his 'prince among patriots', *Netaji*'s name had become one to conjure with. Bose



Q: Which party did he join after quitting the Congress in 1922?

A: Swaraj Party

Q: When did Bose first go to prison and why?

A: In 1921, for organising a boycott against the visit of the Prince of Wales

Q: Whom did he marry?

A: In 1937 he married Emilie Schenkl, an Austrian, who was his secretary

Q: What was the name of INA's all-woman regiment?

A: Rani of Jhansi Regiment

Q: The INA functioned under which government, formed by him?

A: The Azad Hind Government

gained from a series of fasts."

By that time Bose had already summoned his nephew Sisir Kumar Bose and asked him to help plan and execute his escape from India. On the night of January 16-17, 1941, Bose secretly left his Calcutta home, disguised as Muhammad Ziauddin, a north Indian Muslim insurance agent. He was driven by Sisir in a German-made Wanderer car to Gomoh railway junction. There Bose boarded the Delhi-Kalka Mail for the capital where he changed to the Frontier Mail on his way to Peshawar. Pretending to be a deaf and mute Pathan, he trekked across the rugged

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had managed in INA to bridge the many divides of caste, religion and gender. His ability against the odds to achieve Hindu-Muslim unity had invested the INA experiment with its most important contemporary salience. Bose was not just a warrior-hero, even though he may be best remembered as such. He paused between battles to reflect on India's political, economical and social issues. It is the vision of a free India and its global role that accounts for his increasing relevance as time passes.

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